The Payson Morning Scroll

Made Exclusively for the Mogollon's Hearth Guests

"All the news worth knowing before the mead hall opens."

The Greybeards of High Hrothgar — Publisher & Proprietor

Payson, Arizona · Fredas, the 16th of Frostfall (Friday, October 16, 2026) · Morning Edition — Vol. 2610, No. 16 · Price: One Septim



Gandy basks in the Fredas sun while Maevy hunts her butterfly.

Skies o'er the Hold

71° / 48°

Sunny

Sunrise 6:31 AM · Sunset 5:49 PM

Tomorrow — Mostly cloudy, 65/50

The Moon's Reckoning



Yesterday — *Tonight* — Waxing Crescent — *Tomorrow* — First Quarter

waxing toward the full moon

16th of Frostfall = October 16

Months run one-for-one all year

Sundas=Sun … Loredas=Sat

Around the Holds · The Week Ahead

Drums, Easels, and Friday-Night Lights Fill the Holds

Payson, Ariz.

Good Fredas morning, friend of the Hearth — the sun is up over the Rim, the pines stand bright in cool, clear air bound for 71 degrees, and every hold from Payson to Prescott has laid out its best for the start of the weekend. Painters carry their easels to the red rocks as Sedona's Plein Air Festival opens, great drums thunder tonight in Prescott's old opera house, artists stroll Camp Verde's Main Street, and the Longhorns take the field under the lights. Tomorrow brings a bike poker run under the Rim, fall fests, and film screens — by the Nine, traveler, no one need sit idle this weekend.



Painters take their easels to the red rocks while the drums sound — Fredas opens the festival weekend.

Happening in the Holds Today

- **Payson**

  — October Chamber Mixer — 5 PM, The Rim Golf Club, 2000 E Rim Club Dr, Payson. The Rim Country Chamber's monthly mixer gathers the Hold's shopkeepers, makers, and hosts for an easy evening of handshakes and news in a handsome club setting. It is the friendliest room in town for a newcomer to learn who runs what in Rim Country. Come meet the neighbors the Hearth trades with all year.

  — Thatcher vs. Payson — Varsity Football — 7 PM, Payson High School field, Payson. Friday-night lights, Rim Country style: the Payson Longhorns host the Thatcher Eagles in a non-conference home game. Expect the band, the concessions, and half the Hold in the stands cheering the home boys on. A classic fall Fredas for families and football hearts alike.

- **Camp Verde**

  — 3rd Friday Art Walk — 4–6 PM, free, around 646 S 1st St, Camp Verde. The town's monthly third-Friday stroll returns for a relaxed early evening among local artists and downtown stops. It runs just two hours, so arrive on time and take it at a wanderer's pace. Pair it with dinner in Camp Verde or nearby Old Town Cottonwood for a gentle Fredas outing.

  — Scottsdale Christian Academy vs. Camp Verde — Varsity Football — 7 PM, Camp Verde. The Camp Verde Cowboys defend their home field in a conference game under the Friday lights. Small-town football at its warmest — a hometown crowd, a cool desert evening, and a team the whole valley turns out for. Guests who love the game will feel right at home.

- **Sedona**

  — Sedona Plein Air Festival — opening day — runs Oct. 16–24, opening at D.A. Ranch Vineyards, Cornville; tickets through Sedona Arts Center, 15 Art Barn Rd, Sedona. Accomplished outdoor painters from across the country set up their easels around Sedona and the Verde Valley to paint the red rocks live, in the very light you are standing in. Watch canvases take shape, catch demonstrations and exhibitions, and buy original paintings fresh off the easel. The festival runs nine days, so there is time to return.

  — "Bernstein's Wall" — Northern Arizona premiere — showing Oct. 16–22, Mary D. Fisher Theatre, 2030 W State Route 89A, Sedona. The Sedona International Film Festival presents the Northern Arizona premiere of this film at its arthouse theatre in West Sedona. It is a fine pick for film lovers wanting something beyond the multiplex during a red-rock stay. Check the Visit Sedona calendar for the day's showtimes before you ride over.

  — Friday Nights at the Theater — 7–8:30 PM, The New Room at Sedona United Methodist Church, 110 Indian Cliffs Rd, Sedona. The Arts Academy of Sedona's monthly third-Friday showcase is a cabaret-style evening of local music, dance, poetry, comedy, and short dramatic pieces, with light refreshments. Intimate and friendly, it is a low-key way to sample Sedona's own talent in a single evening. Valley Dwellers up for the weekend are most welcome.

- **Prescott**

  — Taiko Extravaganza: Prayer for Peace — 7 PM, Prescott Elks Theater, 117 E Gurley St, Prescott. A thunderous evening of traditional Japanese taiko drumming inside Prescott's historic 1905 opera house, themed as a prayer for peace. Great drums, choreographed movement, and a room built for sound — it will rattle pleasantly in your ribs. A striking night out for music lovers, and the week's most unusual concert in any hold.

  — Autumn Bazaar and Bake Sale — Fri Oct. 16–Sat Oct. 17, 8 AM–3 PM, Prescott. More than twenty artisan vendors bring handmade gifts, with a bake sale, grand drawings, and a silent auction besides. All proceeds benefit local charities, so every septim spent does double duty. An easy early stop for fall and holiday gift hunting that supports the town it sits in.

  — Third Friday Chamber Music — 3–4 PM, Prescott. The Third Friday Chamber Music Series holds its monthly concert, this month featuring a flute quartet organized by Leanne Lawhead alongside local chamber musicians and special guests. One short, civilized hour of music — easy to pair with the bazaar beforehand and dinner downtown after. A gentle way to ease into the weekend.

The Days Ahead

- **Sat, Oct. 17**

  — **Highline Hold'em Mountain Bike Poker Run** — from 9 AM, Landmark at The Creek, 1177 Christopher Creek Loop, Payson. The Rim Country Mountain Biking Association's sixth annual nine-mile poker run on the Highline Trail beneath the Rim. Riders collect seven cards along the trail to build a five-card hand, and the best hands pick prizes back at the Landmark. Paid entry includes a 2026 T-shirt, and proceeds fund signage and care for the Highline's 63 miles.

  — **Fest of Fall** — 12–6 PM, Posse Grounds Park, 525 Posse Ground Rd, Sedona. The City of Sedona's big fall gathering fills one park with food trucks, craft and community vendors, pickleball and cornhole tournaments, a Kids' Zone, a skate-park Ride Jam, a gaming center, and live music. It is run as a low- and zero-waste event, and families can wander it free. Bring a reusable water bottle — it enters you in a raffle.

— **Third Annual Autumn Craft Bazaar** — 9 AM–2 PM, White Mountain United Methodist Church, Show Low. Local White Mountain artisans offer handmade crafts, with children's activities and a bake sale on the side. Proceeds support church projects, the local food pantry, and the Thanksgiving Turkey Dinner Drive. Fall shopping with a community payoff — worth the ride up the mountain.

— **Show Low Film Festival** — Sat Oct. 17–Mon Oct. 19, WME Village 8, 1501 W White Mountain Blvd, Pinetop-Lakeside. In its eighth year, the festival screens roughly a hundred selected independent films across three days, from shorts to features and documentaries. Filmmakers attend in person, with workshops on pitching, entertainment law, and more. Day passes and single-block tickets are on sale; note the films are not yet rated, and the festival says it is not suggested for children.

— **Arizona Blues Hall of Fame Showcase** — 6 PM, Prescott Elks Theater, 117 E Gurley St, Prescott. A showcase concert celebrating Arizona Blues Hall of Fame talent in the historic Elks opera house — the same room that hosts tonight's taiko drums. An evening of blues for fans of the genre, performed by the state's honored players. A strong Loredas-night ticket for the Prescott hold.

- **Mon, Oct. 19**

  — **Music in the Stacks — Open Mic Night** — 4–6:30 PM, free, Camp Verde Community Library, 130 Black Bridge Rd, Camp Verde. The library's open-mic night among the shelves: local musicians and performers take turns in an informal, supportive setting. Come to play a song or simply to listen with a cup of something warm. A cozy Morndas-evening staple for the Verde Valley.

- **Tue, Oct. 20**

  — **Trail Day Volunteer Build** — from 7 AM, Pine, with Pine-Strawberry Fuel Reduction. "Don't just use the trail — help build it": volunteers clear brush, move rocks, break roots, and shape new trail alongside the crew. The work doubles as fire-safety work, improving access routes for firefighters and emergency crews. Open to hikers, bikers, runners, and any traveler who wants to give the forest a morning.

- **Wed, Oct. 21**

  — **Long-Term Water Management Plan Community Meeting** — 1–3 PM, Prescott Public Library, Prescott. City staff present Prescott's developing Long-Term Water Management Plan — current and future water supplies, conservation, and efficiency — in a 45-minute presentation. Informal stations follow, where residents can talk with City representatives and take a community survey. For Prescott folk who want a voice in the town's water future.

Quests of the Hearth

Quests awaiting:

- ☐ **Design & prep the torch sconces** — Overdue since Sept. 26 — draw the sconces and ready them before a single torch can burn.
- ☐ **Print the torch sconces** — Overdue since Oct. 3 — the printers stand ready; give them their orders.
- ☐ **Finish & install the torches** — Overdue since Oct. 10 — hang the finished torches and light the way.
- ☐ **Build the Mogollon's Hearth shield** — Due tomorrow, Saturday, Oct. 17 — the Hearth's arms take shape; mount it by the front door after.

The shield is due tomorrow, Saturday, Oct. 17 — and the torches still wait overdue, wanting their guardians hung and lit.



The Hearth shield on the workbench, with the torch sconces lined up beside it.

Merchant of the Hold

Smashley's Coffee Company · *Payson*



Lattes, cinnamon buns, and olive oils under one timber roof.

A locally owned coffee house tucked inside the Payson Olive Oil Company shop on the Beeline, pouring specialty coffees, Americanos, lattes, and cortados, plus energy drinks and hot chocolate for the road. The signature pour is the Nutty Ex — with the Carrot Cake and Churro Americanos close behind — and the counter carries homemade bakes, from cinnamon buns and cookies to a gluten-free brownie reviewers praise by name. Some small morning enchantment keeps every foam standing tall and every bun warm, or so the regulars swear.

> *"Delicious!!! My husband and I loved our drinks! He got a vanilla latte and I tried the Nutty Ex."* — Tracie O. on Yelp (via Roadtrippers)

614 N Beeline Hwy, Payson · Mon–Sat 7 AM–3 PM, Sun 8 AM–2 PM · (928) 978-6613 · $ (easy on the purse) · Good to know: it sits inside the Payson Olive Oil Company, with a back patio — browse the oils and local goods while your latte is poured. · their scrying-mirror page (other travelers call it a 'website')

Why the Hearth sends you: The Hold's happiest morning stop — creative lattes, homemade bakes, and a patio made for slow starts before a day on the Rim.

Stories Around the Rim

He Was HERE Ten Minutes Ago — Again



The watchtower, the fallen dragon, and the road he left by.

Word came down the south road with a mead trader out of the great walled town, and it is the biggest word yet: a dragon fell at the western watchtower, and our hooded friend was in the middle of it. A guardsman swears the stranger stood in the tower yard while the beast came down, and that when it was done he spoke one word that rolled like thunder off the walls. Another swears the guards did all the work and the fellow only watched — the accounts agree on nothing but the dragon, and that he was gone ten minutes before the trader's cart reached the gate.

Mabel (a wood elf) does not believe a word of it, which is exactly what she said about the barrow. Earl (an elk) has taken to glancing at the sky on his walks. The Hold just missed him again — but by the Nine, the road north sounds lively.

Tales from the Treeline

The Great Pumpkin Weigh-In



The champion pumpkin, its judge, and its captain.

Fredas dawned bright and clear, and Jethro (the Mogollon Monster) declared the First Great Pumpkin Weigh-In open before breakfast. His pumpkin — raised in Mabel's compost corner and proud of it — sat on the Hearth's scale like a small orange hill, while Mabel (a wood elf) read the tally board and sighed in an official capacity.

Earl (an elk) had been appointed judge, mostly because he owns the steadiest face in the forest. He inspected the pumpkin from every side, nodded once with great dignity, and stepped onto the scale himself to check it was honest — at which point the needle spun clean off its pin and the pumpkin took the prize by default.

Henny (the Hearth's chicken) rode the champion pumpkin back to the porch in state, one foot planted like a ship's captain. Gus has already claimed the seeds, Jethro has claimed the glory, and Earl has claimed he was never on the scale at all.

Printed with pride in Payson, in the shadow of the Rim · Set in hot metal by Dude, Bard of the Morning Scroll · May your Fredas be free of wolves, Clay.

Ask the Hearth ✉

…or write to us straight: mogollonshearth@gmail.com